to be a unifying figure for India’s many diverse communities.

Since 1947, fifteen individuals have held the demanding job of being prime minister. Some occupied the role for brief periods, interludes in which they were unable to have a long-lasting impact. Others remained in the role for years, and through their vision and leadership, shaped the nation in significant and enduring ways.

In this section, you will read about five people who have served as prime minister of India since 1947. Each of these individuals had markedly different beliefs about what India should be like politically and socially, what it means to be Indian and what the country’s goals should be, both for its own people and as part of an international community. They also had widely divergent backgrounds, personal beliefs and political principles. That five such varied individuals have all held the highest political office in the land is indicative of India’s political diversity.

JAWAHARLAL NEHRU

1889–1964